



does a lot of things right. It's much easier to acquire the cards you want, and create the decks you want to, without relying too much on RNG, or luck. You can work your way towards the cards you want. While the game shares a lot of elements with other card games, it also has plenty of game-play elements unique to itself, making for a familiar, yet unique experience. Plus, if you're familiar with Riot Games' MOBA, *League of Legends*, *Legends of Runeterra* greatly expands on the lore from the game and brings more character and backstory to the characters from the MOBA.

SLAY THE SPIRE

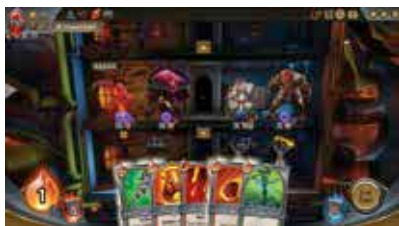
One of the prime examples of Indie genius, combining deck building with roguelike elements, is *Slay the Spire*. The goal of the game is pretty simple:



make your way to the top of the spire. On your way to the top, you will battle hordes of enemies, building your deck as you go. If you're beaten, you'll find yourself all the way back at the bottom. That's where the roguelike element kicks in – no two runs are the same. Meaning you need to rethink your strategy, and rethink the way you build your new deck. A simple goal, but certainly not simple to achieve. The game encourages experimentation with different builds and paths; you never know, the results could be unexpected.

MONSTER TRAIN

Another combination of the roguelike genre and card building, *Monster*



Train has you take command over two out of five demon clans, a primary and secondary clan. This of course determines the kind of cards you'll have access to. In *Monster Train*, you're transporting the last burning pyre to hell, which has frozen over – and this is the only way to save hell, we guess? Your train has three floors, with the pyre sitting on top, and you need to defend it from the angelic armies of heaven. In a way, the game features tower defence elements as well, as the angels move a floor each round until they're defeated.

You can decide the course of the train which determines the bonuses you will get, and you can also upgrade your cards to create powerful combos.

GWENT: THE WITCHER CARD GAME



When *The Witcher 3* dropped, we doubt anybody would have thought that they'd end up spending most of their time in-game playing Gwent. It was a great time sink within the game, building your deck and travelling to taverns around the land in search of powerful cards. Of course, it was a no-brainer for CD Projekt Red to then release *Gwent* as a standalone game. The standalone version of Gwent is slightly different from the version in *The Witcher 3*, and features a lot more spells, units and special abilities. There's a lot more content to learn and master, but hey, if we could do it once in *The Witcher 3*, we can do it again outside of it. Besides, the mechanics aren't all that complicated.



HEARTHSTONE

Probably the most well known CCG out there, *Hearthstone* single handedly put the deck building card battler genre on the map. Well at least, as a video game. It quickly became one of the most played games on the planet, especially during its peak. The game still has a dedicated player base and an active competitive scene.

What made the game so popular? It was simple and easy to pick up, it was charming and full of personality, and it got regular card expansions and events which kept things fresh.

There's also the fact that it's based on Blizzard's *Warcraft* franchise, with plenty of familiar faces and new ones as well. The flavour text, the voice acting, the animations, the board, the expansions and card packs, it all just worked very well, and Blizzard had struck gold with *Hearthstone*.

SHADOWVERSE

If warlocks and warcraft aren't quite your fancy, i.e., you're not quite into Blizzard's whole high fantasy shtick, then *Shadowverse* is a good alternative. When it comes to gameplay, *Shadowverse* is essentially identical to *Hearthstone*, however, the aesthetic is completely different. Instead of a West-



ern RPG aesthetic, *Shadowverse* uses a more Korean MMO anime-esque aesthetic. While gameplay is the same, *Shadowverse* does have some extra mechanics, such as evolution of cards, and powerful faction cards which can lead to some ludicrously powerful decks, if you know what you're doing.